

and final call', it doesn't necessarily mean the gavel is coming down the millisecond after. You'll likely have several seconds to respond.

What sort of bidder will you be?

Here are the main types I see entering the fray – and I have witnessed thousands of bidders at work – as well as how they have won the confrontation in varied but equally successful ways.

The intruder

You wait for the auction to reach a critical point before jumping in and going toe-to-toe with your competition, all in the final stages. The moment of truth will be when the other bidders are slowing down, hinting that they're running out of money, or if bidding is still rollicking at a hard-and-fast rhythm. You will attempt a knockout before it soars above your budget.

Pros

- You can assess how deep your competitions' pockets are. Once you enter the bidding, you will be emotionally invested in the purchase, so biding your time to see if you have a chance will protect you from disappointment.
- You can catch your competition unaware and throw them off their game – suddenly, there's another contender they have to worry about.
- You won't be locked in battle for long – you'll either quickly come in over the top or will have misread your competition – and this is better for your nerves.

Cons

- You need nerves of steel for that short burst and, as a first home buyer, don't underestimate how jittery you will be.
- You won't be in control at the point you enter the auction, so you'll need to be prepared to strongly counter-offer the highest bid to get ahead. This needs a cool head and a strategy, which you will be forming as you watch the auction unfold. In the dying stages, bidding often trickles to \$5000 or \$1000 increments, after starting in the tens of thousands, so to gain the upper hand the best late bidders throw in